

Exercise 2: Research question and research objectives

Examine the following examples of research questions and objectives. They are based on draft research objectives for dissertations that have been submitted at some point by participants on the Master's programmes.

What do you think of the quality of the research questions and objectives? Are they sufficiently clear and specific? If not, how could they be improved?

Example A

Background

This was a proposal from someone who worked in a large hospital (called a 'Trust') in the English National Health Service. She was aware that a new nursing strategy for the hospital had been drawn up and agreed. She had a copy on her shelf, and available on her computer. But she was not convinced that the strategy had been communicated to nurses in the hospital, or that it was being implemented. She decided to use the dissertation to find out if it was understood and if it was being implemented.

Research question, aims and objectives

The research question for this case study asks: Has a new strategy been implemented within XYZ organisation, and how far has the strategy been spread?

The aims of this study are to:-

1. Explore levels of understanding of the new nursing strategy across different grades of nurses.
2. Identify the relevance of the new nursing strategy to them in their roles.
3. Seek to understand nurses' awareness of the origins of the nursing strategy to the Trust strategy.
4. Assess if and how the strategy is being implemented at each level.
5. Identify any difficulties in implementing the strategy.

The objectives of the study are:-

1. Examine literature describing the development and successful implementation of strategy in the NHS.
2. Compare levels of understanding across grades of nurses through evaluation of quantitative data.
3. Identify success of the strategy in mobilising change.

Example B

Background

This study aimed to research the impact of transformational and transactional leadership on innovation and change in a telecom corporation (company S) in Sweden. This large telecom corporation, with over 100, 000 employees was moving into ICT, and the change demanded that company S performed more with fewer resources. The study aimed to investigate whether the two leadership styles efficiently supported innovation and change processes.

Research question and objectives

How do transactional and transformational leaders support and succeed innovation and change in business organisations?

Objectives

1. Critically review literature on transactional and transformational leadership and their impact on innovation and change processes/management
2. Collect data from leaders in the organisation through semi-structured interviews with a focus on how different leadership in company S support innovation and change.
3. Analyse the data collected with a view to understand the important role that business leadership play in assisting organisational change and innovation.